

Co-op Fertility Treatment Policy webpage

[IVF and fertility treatment policy - Co-op Colleagues](#)

Here at the Co-op, we want to support colleagues undergoing fertility treatment. We understand it can be emotionally stressful and colleagues need support, especially if a cycle of treatment is not successful. We also know that sometimes colleagues may need time off work to go to appointments for fertility treatment (including accompanying their partners, surrogate, or co-parent). If you do need time off, speak to your manager as soon as you can to make arrangements for the time you need.

We acknowledge the importance of using inclusive language and where possible we have used 'gender neutral language' in this policy. For the purposes of this policy 'partner' refers to the partner of the person undergoing treatment and includes same sex partners, intended parents and colleagues who have a surrogate or co-parent undergoing treatment.

Crucial bits

This policy covers time off for the purpose of receiving and recovering from the physical and psychological effects of fertility treatment and to attend or accompany your partner/surrogate to appointments specifically connected to the process.

Telling your manager

Talk to your manager as soon as you find out that your treatment, or your partner/surrogate's treatment, has been approved. They will handle things in a sensitive way and treat it as confidential. If you have received medical advice that adjustments are needed to your work duties or pattern while you're undergoing treatment, your manager will talk to you about any adjustments to your work that may need to be made. This may include making adjustments or discussing [flexible working](#) options if medication needs to be self administered during the working day. Your manager may carry out a risk assessment to understand more about how your treatment might affect you at work.

Time off

If you need go to appointments to prepare for or undergo treatment yourself, we'll give you a reasonable amount of paid time off to attend. Let your manager know as early as you can when your appointments are. They might ask to see your appointment card or email/text confirmation to confirm things.

If you need more time off because of the side effects or impact of fertility treatment, this will be managed through the usual [absence policy](#).

If it's just your partner/surrogate, or both you and your partner are undergoing fertility treatment, we know you may want to accompany your partner to their appointments. We know that the number of appointments needed may vary and we don't assume to know what you need. As a guide, we'll generally give paid leave for up to ten appointments per cycle, for up to three cycles of fertility treatment but some situations may need more or less. Your manager will decide so talk to them about your circumstances. Let your manager know as early as you can when any appointments are. Your manager might ask to see a copy of an appointment card or email/text confirmation to confirm things.

It doesn't matter how long you've worked here or how many hours you work; all colleagues are entitled to use this policy if they or their partner/surrogate are undergoing fertility treatment.

If you or your partner/surrogate are undergoing fertility treatment you might also want to consider [flexible working](#) to facilitate further treatment.

Things to think about

Pay

We want your pay to be right, so this should be recorded as Paid Hospital or Dental/Medical Visit, as agreed with your manager.

Embryo Transfer

If you have been undergoing fertility treatment and have had the last part of the IVF process (embryo transfer) you have pregnancy rights. This means that you are protected against unfair dismissal and unfair treatment related to your possible pregnancy. You do not have to tell your manager at this stage but you may find it helpful so they can offer support.

If your IVF treatment is unsuccessful, you are still protected by law against pregnancy discrimination for 2 weeks after a positive pregnancy test. If this happens to you or your surrogate, you may also find the support in our pregnancy loss policy helpful. Our [pregnancy loss policy](#) still applies if a loss occurs from the point of embryo transfer onwards.

Counselling and Wellbeing Support

We understand that undergoing fertility treatment can be emotionally stressful.

You can access free, professional and confidential counselling 24 hours a day through Telus Health. The best way to access this is via the mobile app or if you prefer you can call them on 0800 069 8854. More information about Telus Health and our EAP (Employee Assistance Programme) can be found [here](#)

YuDoctor provides virtual health services from 24/7 GP appointments to second medical opinions and proactive health guidance. YuDoctor is completely confidential and nobody at the Co-op will be provided with access to any information you share. For more information on how to access, visit our [Wellbeing Hub](#)

If you are looking for support with exercise, nutrition and making healthy lifestyle choices there is support available through both our [Wellbeing Hub] and Telus Health app. As a Co-op colleague you can also access our [YuLife offer](#) which offers incentives and rewards for building healthy habits.

We know that undergoing fertility treatment may cause a strain on your finances. We have a number of products that may support your financial wellbeing including [Salary Finance](#) [Wagestream](#) and [Credit Unions](#)

If you need further support

If you have any questions about time off for fertility treatment, please speak to your manager. If managers need advice, they can contact [ER Services](#).

Remember we have a colleague support programme, which gives you access to a 24/7 colleague helpline – 08088 021 122. Rest assured this is a completely confidential, independent helpline which is free to access.

There are lots of charities and specialist support groups who offer support and information. Here are some that you might find helpful:

- [Fertility Network UK](#) – the National Charity for anyone who has ever experienced fertility problems.
- [Fertility Friends](#) – an online community dedicated to infertility and fertility support
- [bica.net](#) – The British Infertility Counselling Association which signposts to specialist fertility counsellors
- [Surrogacy UK](#) – a not for profit one stop shop for all information about surrogacy in the UK
- [Human Fertilisation & Embryology Authority](#) – a government body with lots of supporting information for everyone whatever their situation
- [Tommy's](#) – pregnancy charity funding pioneering research to understand why pregnancy goes wrong. Tommy's provides expert, midwife led advice for parents before, during and after pregnancy

Managers' Guides

[Fertility Treatment - Managers Guide](#)

[Fertility Treatment - Short guide for Managers](#)